

Bridging Factions: A Meet-up Connecting Diverse Perspectives in Human-Computer Interaction

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Abstract

Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) flourishes through methodological diversity, encompassing computational, human-centric, theoretical, and integrative traditions. While this richness strengthens the field, it can also foster silos and misunderstandings. Computational work may be perceived as rigid, human-centric approaches as less rigorous, theoretical perspectives as abstract, and integrators as “jack-of-all-trades-master-of-none.” The Bridging Factions meet-up provides a friendly and inclusive environment for CHI attendees to acknowledge, explore, and connect across these divides. Through activities such as a post-it notes interests wall and speed networking, participants will identify shared interests, discover unexpected overlaps, and establish new connections across HCI “factions.” The session welcomes researchers, students, educators, and industry professionals—no prior expertise is necessary. By the conclusion of the meet-up, attendees will have expanded their networks, gained shared insights into cross-faction collaboration, and developed a stronger appreciation for how diverse approaches in HCI can complement one another.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Human computer interaction (HCI).

Keywords

HCI Factions, Skills, Knowledge, Experiences, Collaboration, Futures

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1 Introduction and Background

Our world is naturally divided by geography, generation, income, interests, and other factors. We naturally gravitate toward forming groups (or “pockets”) based on shared characteristics and interests [3, 12] exhibits this tendency, with disciplines developing their own methodologies, languages, and cultures. While resources and spaces may be shared, meaningful cross-disciplinary dialogue is often scarce. Recent initiatives, such as the UKRI Cross-Research Council Responsive Mode Pilot [44] and the German Reproducibility Network (GRN) [11], aim to dissolve traditional silos and foster collaboration across boundaries. Within the field of computing, the *ACM Computing Classification System (CCS)* [1] categorises 13 sub-fields, including Human-Centred Computing. Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) encompasses various design methods, interaction paradigms, devices, theoretical frameworks, models, techniques, tools, and empirical studies [19, 36]. Despite this abundance of knowledge, HCI communities often remain siloed: departments may house diverse expertise under one roof, yet invisible boundaries hinder collaboration, [4, 9]. The motivation for this meet-up stems from the organisers’ experiences in interdisciplinary HCI

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Figure 1: (Top Left) Informal civic care and sustainability—building ‘bunds’. Photography. Anna R L Carter. (Top Right) “Jamming” shape-changing interface, white box prototype from user study, [38]. Miriam Sturdee. (Middle Left) Co-created “Art Table”. Mixed Media. Miriam Sturdee et al. [42]. (Middle Right) One after the other. Digital sketch on Lenovo Yoga C930. Denise Lengyel. (Bottom Left) Going in Circles. Felt pens on paper. Denise Lengyel. (Bottom Centre) Extract from ‘history of microcomputers and early gaming’ exhibitions. Photography. Paul Neve. (Bottom Right) Trusting “Nature”, [22]. Apple Pencil on iPad Pro 11 using Procreate. Makayla Lewis.

collaboration, encompassing computational, human-centric, theoretical, and integrative perspectives, presenting advantages and challenges. Examples include iterative workshops that combine dance and digital technology, e.g., [10], as well as artistic HCI outputs such as sketching, e.g., [8, 16, 23, 24], which may be perceived as “less rigorous”, [2]. Differences in priorities, methodologies, and

language can generate friction, but also present opportunities to identify insights and foster collaboration when facilitated in structured and playful ways. This was evident in informal discussions held by the organisers when brainstorming this meet-up’s concept, reflecting on positive and challenging aspects of their HCI work. For instance, *Practical and theoretical knowledge*: “My research

collaborators and students express a high value for the practical and theoretical knowledge I bring to the table, including human-centred, computational-centred, and theory-based aspects. This knowledge enriches our joint work.” **Collaborative dance workshops:** “A dancer I worked with appreciated my systematic workshop approach: small iterative modifications of the tech setup and dance conditions based on our theoretical and practical understanding of dance and technology, observations and feedback.” **Artistic outputs and sketching:** “It’s aesthetically pleasing, but do you have any data to support it?”—highlighting scepticism towards artistic contributions. “I lack drawing skills, so I could not participate in this...”—expressing limitations. **Collaboration across domains:** “Any projects that achieved remote success required everyone involved to compromise and demonstrate tolerance, particularly the developers!” [29].

1.1 Preliminary HCI Factions

Four informal factions (inspired by the Divergent series [17]) exist in HCI, aligned by research approach rather than formal subfields. **Computational Faction:** This faction concentrates on algorithms, code, and system performance, emphasising technology’s functionality and technical mechanics. For instance, a personalised recommendation engine employing a combinatorial algorithm for online learning investigates the development of a recommendation system that integrates association rules, content and collaborative filtering, e.g., [13, 37, 43]. **Human-Centric Faction:** Emphasises creative methods such as sketching, arts, and hands-on making. This faction prioritises human engagement through qualitative and innovative approaches to explore social and cultural experiences, as exemplified by [7, 25, 26, 40]. They are facing criticism of being too focused on application and individuals rather than foundational research, though it has long been argued in other disciplines that the distinction between basic and applied research is too vague and oversimplified, [33]. The computational faction might require more analytical rigour of the human-centric faction, while they in turn may perceive the former as excessively rigid. They may critique each other for prioritising efficiency over ethics, overlooking technology’s social and philosophical implications, and proposing biologically impossible solutions. **Theoretical Faction:** Develops theoretical frameworks for accounting for HCI, drawing from cognitive science, social psychology, linguistics, philosophy, and other disciplines. They use these frameworks to guide design and analysis, and employ HCI to comprehend interactive human behaviour, e.g. [14, 34]. **Integrative Faction:** Within these three factions lies a smaller fourth group. They are often proficient in development and system design, skilled in qualitative and creative methods, and keenly interested in experiential practices, [8, 15, 18, 20, 21, 31, 32]. However, their integrative way of working opens them up to criticisms faced, for example, by both the human-centric as well as the theoretical faction. Additionally, they risk being dismissed as a ‘Jack of all trades, master of none’, [30, 35, 45].

2 Goal of the Meet-up

The *Bridging Factions* meet-up aims to encourage mutually beneficial cross-factional engagement within the HCI community. It will

create a welcoming and informal atmosphere to support participants to recognise their factions, understand others’, and identify collaboration opportunities.

3 Description of the Community

The *Bridging Factions* meet-up is open to all attendees of the CHI 2026 conference, regardless of their background. This includes researchers seeking cross-methodological collaboration, educators exploring how to teach diverse HCI approaches, industry professionals interested in integrating technical, human-centred, and theoretical insights, students and early career researchers exploring their place in HCI, and anyone interested in the field.

4 Overview of the meetup

The *Bridging Factions* 90-minute in-person meetup is speed networking—informal and participant-led. **Introduction and Framing (5 minutes):** Presentation of HCI factions, outline of session’s objectives and activity. **Part Two: Post-it Wall of Interests (15 minutes):** Participants to write down their research interests, skills, curiosities, or project ideas. Lightning affinity diagramming technique to identify intersections of expertise and potential connections among the clusters. **Group Matchmaking (10 minutes):** Organisers to quickly curate matches and a schedule projected using Miro. **Faction Speed Networking (40 minutes, 3 Rounds):** Each timed 1:1 session guided by prompts projected using Miro. Prompts include: What is your primary focus? Which faction aligns best with your interests? What challenges do you face in your work that another faction might address? **Reflection and Next Steps (5 minutes):** Participants invited to share their insights, any connections made, or potential avenues for future collaboration. For accessibility concerns, please see Supplementary Material.

5 Organisers and Suitability

The organising team represents a diverse range of HCI expertise, encompassing computational, human-centric, theoretical, and integrative approaches. This comprehensive expertise equips them to facilitate this inclusive, engaging, and boundary-pushing meet-up effectively. **Makayla Lewis** is a Senior Lecturer and Artist in Computer Science at Kingston University London, UK. She teaches and researches accessibility, UX design, and integrating sketching/arts in designing emerging technology, e.g., [22, 25, 27]. **Denise Lengyel** is a Visiting Researcher at Newcastle University, UK and HCI Consultant. Her research explores arts-based methods, including drawing, storytelling, and dance, through empirical and theoretical approaches, e.g., [8, 26]. **Miriam Sturdee** is a Senior Lecturer at University of St Andrews, UK with a PhD in digital innovation. She specialises in the role of sketching in designing complex technologies and arts-based approaches in STEM, focusing on future interactions and user experiences, e.g., [39, 41]. **Paul Neve** is a Senior Lecturer in Computer Science at Kingston University, UK. A software engineer, researching programming pedagogy and developing learning support tools, see his microcomputer exhibition. **Farzana Rahman** is a Senior Computer Science (Data Science) Lecturer at Kingston University, UK. Her research focuses on machine learning and large language models applied to health and climate data, e.g., BBI Journal. **Anna R L Carter** is an Innovation

Fellow at Northumbria University, UK. She has extensive experience designing playful, multisensory technologies for local council regeneration programs, e.g., [5, 6, 34]. **Mauro Toselli** is an Independent Artist and Chief Technical Officer at an Italian Solution Provider who uses sketchnotes to explore, understand, and resolve problems, e.g., [28] and his website.

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